Uppsala University

Master's Thesis

Thesis Proposal

Applying Transformative Game Design Theory to Competitive Debate

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1 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Brief Overview

Through this thesis project, I apply transformative game design theory and best practices to create a new competitive debating format. This research employs Research through Design (RtD) methodology to develop and playtest an alternative debate format that addresses systematic problems in widely-used formats, particularly World Schools and British Parliamentary debate.

1.2 Motivation

I decided to engage in this labor in order to give back to the community that shaped me most. I have been deeply engaged with competitive debating for 15 years. As a high school student, I was active in the Romanian and international World Schools debating circuits, participating in over 50 competitions and representing my country at the World Schools Debating Championship. Beyond high school, I participated in hundreds of debate competitions worldwide as a debater, judge, club manager, chief adjudicator, competition organizer and coach. I have spent the vast majority of my time between ages 15 and 25 within the debate world, and even afterwards have remained deeply engaged with the community.

I believe debate is a class of role-playing games with immense transformative potential. I have experienced it firsthand, and personally owe most of my foundational skills and attitudes to my time as a dedicated debater. I have also witnessed as a teacher, trainer and coach hundreds of adolescents and young adults transformed by it, mostly for the better. In the meantime I developed strong opinions on how the transformative potential of most major formats, especially World Schools, is stunted by their design. Furthermore, this design of theirs is completely calcified, and game design theories and practices are not at all used in any attempt to improve them.

1.3 Problem Statement

Based on my fifteen years of observation, participation, and informal conversations with fellow practitioners, I hypothesize that the two most popular debate formats, World Schools and British Parliamentary, whose communities in Europe are deeply intertwined, exhibit the following problematic tendencies:

First, they seem to push debaters towards value convergence, potentially causing them to become less tolerant of people with different values and diminishing their ability to convince people from different backgrounds. Second, they appear to teach debaters to speak very fast and with extreme information density, which could diminish their ability to meaningfully support their positions to people not trained as debate judges. Third, in my opinion they push communities towards hierarchical behavior that undermines psychological safety.

These observations, while grounded in extensive practitioner experience, have not been systematically validated through empirical research and this thesis does not intend to extensively prove them. However, it does try to frame my process of designing a format that

addresses these hypothesized problems, and through that design process, to generate evidence about how these problems are triggered by the design of the game.

1.4 Research Question

How can the application of transformative game design theory inform the creation of a competitive debate format that is a better transformative container?

1.5 Scope and Limitations

This thesis aims to demonstrate proof of concept: that alternative debate formats can be systematically designed to address problems, and that such designs produce observable and articulable differences in participant experience. In particular it will try to demonstrate how a debate format can address one or more of the identified problems without sacrificing entertainment value, competitive appeal or educational potential.

The thesis does not aim to produce robust claims about long-term educational efficacy or entertainment value, as such claims would require longitudinal studies with larger samples than a master's thesis permits. Its main contribution to knowledge is the simple proof that debate formats can be designed better if looked at as roleplaying games. That is why the research will involve only approximately 10 playtest sessions over two months with experienced debaters from the Romanian debate community, culminating in qualitative analysis of observational and interview data that should be sufficient to prove how the methodology of design employed by this study can be systematically used to improve the debate landscape.

2 BACKGROUND

2.1 Topic Overview

Academic debate formats are games. Following Salen and Zimmerman's influential definition in *Rules of Play* (Salen & Zimmerman, 2004, p. 80), "a game is a system in which players engage in an artificial conflict, defined by rules, that results in a quantifiable outcome." Academic debate clearly satisfies all these criteria: it has rules, participants, winners, losers, tournaments, and scoring systems. Alfred "Tuna" Snider's 1982 doctoral dissertation "Gaming as a Paradigm for Academic Debate" at the University of Kansas, along with his subsequent publication (Snider, 1984), established the scholarly foundation for viewing debate as a game whilst also indexing and robustly proving its many educational benefits.

Empirical studies demonstrate debate's significant educational benefits. Mezuk's research on the Chicago Debate League (Mezuk, 2009) found that debate participants were 70% more likely to graduate and three times less likely to drop out than non-debaters. Colbert and Biggers (1985) noted that debaters benefit in critical thinking, communication skills, and engagement with subject matter. A meta-analysis by Allen et al. (1999) found significant positive effects of forensics and communication education on critical thinking abilities across multiple studies. More recently, Bellon (2000) synthesized research from competitive

forensics, communication pedagogy, and educational psychology to provide a comprehensive justification for debate across the curriculum.

However, I have yet to find any paper that critiques major formats from a game design perspective or presents academic debating as a role-playing game, though Bowman's 2014 literature review (Bowman, 2014) acknowledges related pedagogical approaches such as process drama and simulation as role-playing games.

Addressing this gap in literature, applying game design lenses and expertise to the analysis and improvement of debate formats, is the main contribution to knowledge that I seek to start making through this paper.

2.2 Debate as Role-Playing Game

In the World Schools format, in every debate there are two teams which receive a motion (e.g., "This House Would legalize the possession of drugs"). Teams are randomly assigned to opposite sides: Proposition/Government or Opposition. They deliver alternating speeches as if they were individuals supporting or opposing the motion. Judges listen as someone with no opinion on the motion, expert in debate rules, and averagely informed, deciding who most convinced the character they role-play. The debate ends with the judge ruling who won, explaining their decision and then offering feedback for improvement to the teams.

Understanding debate's relationship to role-playing games requires first establishing what role-playing games are and where debate fits among related practices. As Zagal and Deterding (2024) observe, defining role-playing games is notoriously contentious, with scholars, designers, and practitioners disagreeing across forms, styles, and communities. However, certain characteristics commonly recur: role-playing games are play activities revolving around the rule-structured creation and enactment of characters in a fictional world, where players define and pursue their own goals with considerable choice in what actions they can attempt (Zagal & Deterding, 2024). Bowman et al. (2025) offer a functional definition: analog role-playing games are "co-creative experiences in which participants immerse into fictional characters and realities for a bounded period of time and improvise through spontaneous, emergent playfulness" (p. 16).

The transformative role-playing game design literature explicitly positions certain activities as "cousin forms" of analog role-playing games (Bowman, 2014; Bowman et al., 2025). These include simulations, educational role-playing, improv theatre, psychodrama, and notably, debate. As Bowman et al. (2025) explain, they "consider these aforementioned uses of role-playing as a practice in education and therapy as 'cousin forms,' reserving role-playing games to refer to activities emerging out of the aforementioned subcultural activities, i.e., arising from leisure play and discourse communities" (p. 15). The distinction rests not on the act of role-playing itself, which "is much the same regardless of community," but on the practices, norms, discussions, and innovations that develop within each community.

For the analytical purpose of usefully employing the body of theory developed to explain how and how better can role-playing games harness positive transformative energies, this is already enough to justify the following section. As will be later revealed, most of the theory developed in what I call the "Nordic School" of roleplaying game design explains processes common to all role-playing activities. Going even further, competitive debate occupies an unusual position among these cousin forms, one that warrants closer examination. While

debate is indeed used in educational contexts, it differs fundamentally from close cousins such as work simulations or classroom exercises in ways that bring it closer to analog role-playing games proper. Three theoretical dimensions illuminate this proximity: the depth of character immersion, the strength of alibi, and the leisure-community dimension.

First, regarding immersion: in board games, players manipulate pieces representing characters but do not adopt those characters' perspectives; the player of Chess does not think as a medieval king. In work simulations, participants practice skills but typically as themselves facing hypothetical scenarios; a medical student practicing bedside manner remains cognitively positioned as a student learning correct behavior. Debate requires something qualitatively different. Debaters must genuinely inhabit an epistemic stance, constructing and defending arguments as if they believed them. This process of active perspective-taking requires what Bowman (2010) calls developing a "theory of mind" outside one's own. The debater must anticipate objections, identify weaknesses, and respond to challenges as someone who holds the assigned position, a cognitive demand that approaches the immersion into character central to role-playing games. I myself felt and many colleague debaters also expressed how the extreme cognitive load that performance in debate demands is incompatible with not fully assuming for the duration of the debate the opinion demanded by the motion, only to then discard it easily in time for the next debate (especially in a competition).

This immersion operates at the level of epistemic stance rather than fictional biography. Following Hammer et al. (2024), character adoption in role-playing enables perspective-taking: the appreciation for and understanding of others' unique psychological points of view. Perspective-taking develops through imagining the experiences of others, precisely what debaters must do when assigned to defend positions they personally oppose. Bowman (2010) identifies nine types of relationships between players and characters, including the "Fragmented Self," where a facet of the player's personality or interests becomes magnified into a central character trait. Debate characters fit this framework: they represent fragmented selves whose defining feature is epistemic commitment to a particular position. The debater role-plays as someone who believes the motion should pass or fail, adopting that argumentative perspective as the character's core identity. They find in themselves beliefs they can hold that support the position and banish from thought all other, focusing on a fragment of their identity.

Second, regarding alibi: the concept of alibi, as theorized by Deterding and Dixon (2018), describes how participants in games can act with lessened social consequences, encouraging risk-taking and willingness to fail. Work simulations provide limited alibi because participants know they are being evaluated on correct performance; the simulation's purpose is precisely to judge whether they can do the task properly. Debate, by contrast, provides robust alibi through its explicitly competitive and playful frame. Because debate is "just a game," it demands of participants to advance positions they might not advocate publicly, explore arguments they find uncomfortable, and fail without lasting consequences to their professional standing or personal reputation. This alibi enables the kind of identity experimentation, in this case on epistemic stances, that Bowman et al. (2025) identify as central to transformational containers.

Third, regarding the leisure-community dimension: unlike simulations designed for professional training or classroom activities, competitive debate possesses the passionate discourse communities that Bowman et al. (2025) identify as distinguishing role-playing games

from cousin forms. The World Schools and British Parliamentary competitive circuits, in Europe alone I have seen to encompass over hundreds of national and international competitions. Debaters participate voluntarily, often for decades (me included); they develop specialized terminology, shared references, and community norms; they attend tournaments and conferences analogous to gaming conventions; they debate the nature and purpose of their activity and the interpretation of minute elements of the rules with fervor matching any role-playing community's edition wars. The activity is often pursued for its intrinsic satisfactions, not merely as preparation for external goal (and sometimes at great financial and time-commitment odds with them). This leisure dimension, combined with the vibrant discourse community, positions competitive debate closer to role-playing games than to the educational simulations with which it shares surface similarities.

Furthermore, evidence for debate's role-playing dimension appears throughout its practice. Experienced coaches regularly employ explicit role-playing techniques during preparation, asking debaters to "become" stakeholders affected by policies. As Snider (1999) emphasizes, the better debater "portrays an image of an intelligent person who is seeking to understand and discover the truth," a fundamentally performative stance requiring adoption of a character oriented toward inquiry rather than mere victory. Furthermore, debate ethos as I witnessed it is summoned through traditions that explicitly stage parliamentary fiction: bench-pounding, heckling, Points of Information delivered as if holding onto wigs. The format performs a fiction of parliamentary deliberation, with debaters and judges alike participating in theatrical conventions inherited from eighteenth-century British debate culture.

Genuine differences between debate and games that are more traditionally seen as analogue role-playing games, such as Dungeons and Dragons, are undeniable: debate lacks the narrative worldbuilding, the character backstories, and the extended campaign structures of tabletop or live-action role-playing. But it is important to recognize that debate's role-playing operates through the same psychological mechanisms and creates the same kind of transformational container that role-playing game scholarship has theorized. This positioning justifies applying the substantial body of transformative game design scholarship to understand how debate produces its educational effects and, more importantly, how design choices might enhance or undermine those effects. The problems identified in current formats, including value convergence, non-transferable speaking skills, and toxic hierarchies can be and are in the next chapters reconceptualized as failures in specific mechanisms of bleed and container maintenance, suggesting targeted design interventions that role-playing game scholarship has already developed.

3 LITERATURE REVIEW

The usefulness of applying transformative game design theory to attempt solving the problems of current debate formats comes also from the apparent failure of current scholarly works in the same endeavor. Although debate is also critiqued in communication theory and treated as a tool in educational theory, the largest body of work that analyzes it as an educational tool is that of forensics pedagogy.

3.1 Forensics Pedagogy and Educational Benefits

Within forensics pedagogy, a substantial body of research establishes the educational value of competitive debate.Bellon (2000) synthesized this research tradition, arguing that debate develops research skills, analytical abilities, and oral communication competencies that transfer to academic and professional contexts.

These benefits have been attributed to several mechanisms. The adversarial structure requires debaters to anticipate counterarguments, developing what Kuhn (2005) calls "argumentative competence." The switch-side practice, requiring debaters to argue both for and against propositions regardless of personal belief, has been theorized as developing perspective-taking abilities and reducing dogmatism (Harrigan, 2008). The iterative cycle of preparation, performance, and feedback mirrors effective learning structures identified in educational psychology (Kolb, 1984). Snider's later work, particularly his collaboration with Maxwell Schnurer in *Many Sides: Debate Across the Curriculum* (Snider & Schnurer, 2002), emphasized debate's civic and democratic foundations. Snider and Schnurer argued that structured classroom debates facilitate numerous pedagogical benefits including deepening students' comprehension of course content and enthusiasm for subject matter. *Empowerment* occurs as students discover their capacity for effective public argumentation, particularly for students from backgrounds where such skills were not previously modeled. *Research skill development* emerges from the intensive preparation process requiring debaters to locate, evaluate, and synthesize evidence. *Oral communication proficiency* develops through repeated practice of structured public speaking under time pressure. *Critical thinking* is cultivated through the constant requirement to analyze arguments, identify weaknesses, and construct counterarguments.

3.2 Forensics Pedagogy and Educational Drawbacks

While the forensics literature generally celebrates debate's benefits, critical perspectives have identified ways in which competitive optimization may undermine educational goals. Part of these critiques focus on two interrelated concerns that I also share: the relationship between debate and authentic conviction and the transferability of debate skills.

Merrell et al. (2015) examined how competitive practices transferred from tournaments to classrooms can be "problematic or even detrimental when adopted in introductory courses," suggesting that optimization for competitive success may diverge from educational goals. Greene and Hicks (2005) offered a critical analysis of switch-side debating as a "cultural technology of liberalism," arguing that the practice separates speech from conviction in ways that may produce "exceptional subjects" whose deliberative skills serve institutional rather than personal ends. While subsequent scholarship has contested Greene and Hicks's conclusions (English et al., 2007), their critique highlights that debate's educational effects are not uniformly positive and depend substantially on design and implementation. The tension they identify, between developing flexible argumentative skills and maintaining authentic connection to one's positions, remains unresolved in forensics scholarship.

The phenomenon of "spreading" (speaking at extremely rapid rates to maximize information density) in American policy debate has been criticized as optimizing for competitive advantage at the expense of communicative accessibility (Herbeck & Katsulas, 1987). While

World Schools and British Parliamentary formats explicitly discourage spreading through style-based evaluation, similar pressures toward information density exist, and the skills developed may not transfer to contexts without expert judges.

3.3 Gap Identification

This literature review reveals a significant gap in literature. Forensics pedagogy, which most studies debate, has established debate's educational benefits and identified some tensions, but has not systematically applied game design frameworks to analyze how specific format mechanics produce specific effects. Transformative role-playing game theory provides sophisticated tools for understanding how structured play produces personal change, but has not yet been applied to competitive debate. This gap is analytically productive: it suggests that insights from transformative role-playing game research might illuminate both why debate produces its documented benefits and how format design choices might enhance or undermine those effects. Addressing this gap is the central contribution of this thesis.

4 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This section develops an integrated theoretical framework for analyzing how competitive debate produces transformative effects and how design interventions might enhance those effects. The framework synthesizes insights from transformative role-playing game theory, learning theory, and procedural rhetoric, demonstrating how these lenses combine to explain debate's transformative mechanisms and guide design decisions.

4.1 Core Theoretical Constructs

4.1.1 The Transformational Container

The concept of the transformational container, drawn from psychoanalytic theory (Bion, 1961; Winnicott, 1960) and adapted to role-playing games by Bowman and Hugaas (2021), provides the foundational structure for understanding how debate enables personal growth. A transformational container is a bounded space, whether physical, social, or psychological, that provides sufficient safety for participants to take risks and experiment with new ways of being. This connects to Huizinga (1958) concept of the "magic circle," the boundary separating game space from ordinary life, though contemporary scholarship recognizes this boundary as porous rather than absolute.

Debate creates a transformational container through several mechanisms. The explicit rules and conventions establish clear boundaries separating the debate space from ordinary interaction. The competitive frame paradoxically enables safety through alibi (Deterding & Dixon, 2018): because debate is "just a game," participants can advance positions they might not advocate publicly, explore arguments they find uncomfortable, and fail without lasting consequences. The judge serves as a containing authority figure who ensures rules are followed and provides structured feedback.

However, the container's effectiveness depends on its design. If competitive pressures become overwhelming, if hierarchies within the community become rigid, or if certain participants feel systematically excluded, the container's transformational potential is compromised. This framework predicts that design choices affecting psychological safety will directly impact transformative outcomes.

4.1.2 Bleed as Transformative Mechanism

Following Hugaas (2024), bleed describes the bidirectional spillover of psychological contents between player and character (or in debate, between the debater and their assigned position). This concept is crucial for understanding how debate produces its educational effects.

Memetic bleed, the transfer of ideas and perspectives, explains how debaters develop epistemic humility. First of all through the very direct memetic bleed of the opinions of the role played in a debate towards the debater, arguments which can be summoned again outside of the debate. But more than that, after years of arguing for positions contrary to their beliefs, debaters bleed into accepting that reasonable people can formulate opposing views, that anything can be argued convincingly, and that argumentative power does not equate with being right.

This bleed of a certain humble attitude connects to Bogost (2007) concept of procedural rhetoric. Bogost argues that every game, though its systems and rules, reflects a certain world-view, that players in time may be persuaded of. The rules of debate inherently postulate that anyone can support anything and that through dialectic processes of presenting arguments for and against, not truth is reached, but a showcase of who is more capable in argument (as two opposite decisions could be taken in two different rounds on the same motion). Thus experienced debaters ideally learn to acknowledge how there may be much truth in the points made also by the less skilled in argument.

Procedural bleed, the transfer of physical abilities and habits, explains skill development. The rhetorical habits, speaking patterns, and argumentative reflexes developed through competition bleed into debaters' ordinary communication, producing the documented improvements in public speaking and critical thinking.

Emancipatory bleed (Kemper, 2017, 2020) explains debate's particular power for students from marginalized backgrounds. For students where eloquent public speaking was not modeled, debate provides a transformational container to discover and develop their voice. Being taken seriously as intellectuals, having ideas weighed on merits rather than dismissed based on identity, produces lasting changes in self-concept and capability.

4.1.3 Zone of Proximal Development and Scaffolded Learning

Vygotsky (1978) concept of the zone of proximal development, the space between independent accomplishment and achievement with guidance, explains how debate creates naturally occurring scaffolding. Debaters are power-paired against similar-skill teams, ensuring challenges remain within the zone where growth occurs. Judges provide post-debate feedback, offering the guided instruction that enables advancement.

Following Kolb (1984) experiential learning cycle (concrete experience, reflective observation, abstract conceptualization, active experimentation), each debate round provides con-

crete experience, feedback sessions create reflective observation space, preparation requires abstract conceptualization, and the next round permits active experimentation. The debrief, which Crookall (2014) and Daniau (2016) identify as essential to transformation, is built into debate through the oral critique where judges explain reasoning, identify strengths and weaknesses, and offer improvements.

4.2 Reframing Forensics Pedagogy Critiques through Transformative Game Design

The critiques identified within forensics pedagogy, echoing the issues identified during the problem statement, can be productively reframed through the theoretical mechanisms of transformative game design, illuminating not only why these problems occur but also suggesting design-based interventions.

4.2.1 Switch-Side Debate, Container Safety and Failures of Memetic Bleed

Greene and Hicks's critique of switch-side debate and my own observation of value convergence can be understood as two manifestations of the same underlying failure mode in memetic bleed. The intended transformative outcome of switch-side practice is that debaters bleed into the epistemic humility of coming to appreciate that reasonable people can hold opposing views and that argumentative skill does not determine truth. Both critiques identify how this intended bleed trajectory can go awry, producing instead either detachment from conviction or convergence toward narrow evaluative frameworks.

Greene and Hicks argue that switch-side debate produces "exceptional subjects" whose deliberative skills become alienated from personal conviction. Rather than bleeding into humility *about* their positions while maintaining authentic engagement, debaters may bleed into a generalized detachment from conviction altogether, learning that conviction itself is naive or strategically disadvantageous. My observation of value convergence identifies a complementary failure: rather than developing appreciation for genuinely diverse perspectives, debaters converge toward shared evaluative frameworks that paradoxically narrow their argumentative repertoire.

These phenomena are two sides of the same coin, both rooted in the interaction between memetic bleed and the strategic demands of competitive success. The mechanism operates as follows: debate formats position judges as arbiters who role-play "neutral and averagely-informed individuals." However, this role is vague and cognitively demanding, making judges susceptible to what might be termed *evaluative bleed-in* as their own perspectives, values, and argumentative preferences bleed into their judging. When judges share common backgrounds (often academic, often from similar ideological contexts), their collective bleed-in produces systematic biases in what arguments are rewarded.

Furthermore the transformational container requires psychological safety for participants to take risks and experiment without lasting social consequences. Judges, as much as debaters, are participants in the game who require container protection to perform their role authentically. When judges face potential shunning from fellow judges, debaters, or coaches for evaluations that deviate from community norms, the container has failed them. They

cannot take the intellectual risk of authentic evaluation because the social stakes have become too real. The alibi that should protect experimental judgment has eroded.

This container failure for judges produces a specific downstream effect on debaters' memetic bleed. Judges under pressure to self-censor converge toward "safe" evaluations based on perceived community consensus rather than genuine assessment. This homogenization of judicial evaluation means that debaters receive consistent feedback pointing toward the same narrow set of argumentative approaches. What bleeds into debaters is thus not diverse perspectives on argumentation but rather the artifact of judges' constrained decision-making. The memetic content transferred is the community's strategic equilibrium rather than genuine intellectual diversity.

In transformative game design terms, the container's compromise at one level (judges) corrupts the bleed mechanisms at another level (debaters), illustrating how container integrity must be maintained for all participants if transformative outcomes are to be achieved.

Debaters, optimizing for competitive success, adapt strategically to these judicial expectations. Arguments that succeed in out-rounds or from high-status debaters become templates; approaches that align with perceived judicial values propagate through communities. This strategic homogenization is itself a form of memetic bleed as debaters internalize the evaluative frameworks that produce success. But crucially, what bleeds is not epistemic humility; it is a specific, narrowed set of "debate-approved" values and argumentative approaches.

My own critique and that found in forensics pedagogy thus describe different experiential outcomes of the same structural problem. Some debaters, recognizing that success requires adapting to arbitrary judicial preferences, bleed into cynical detachment, the alienation Greene and Hicks describe. Others, internalizing the rewarded frameworks as genuinely correct, bleed into value convergence, mistaking strategic adaptation for intellectual development. In both cases, the intended bleed toward appreciating genuine perspectival diversity fails to occur. The procedural rhetoric of the format teaches not that reasonable people disagree, but that certain approaches win and others lose, a lesson that produces either cynicism or conformity rather than humility.

This reframing suggests that the problem lies not in switch-side practice per se, but in format designs that allow evaluative bleed-in from judges to distort the memetic bleed experienced by debaters. Formats might address this by diversifying the audiences debaters must persuade and strengthening judge alibi, thus reducing the strategic value of adapting to any single evaluative framework; by structuring debriefing processes that help debaters distinguish between strategic adaptation and genuine intellectual development; or by making explicit the distinction between "what wins debates" and "what constitutes good reasoning," preventing the conflation that produces both alienation and convergence.

4.2.2 Information Density and Misaligned Procedural Bleed

The critique of spreading and information-dense speaking styles can be understood as a misalignment in procedural bleed. Procedural bleed transfers physical abilities, habits, and embodied practices from game contexts to ordinary life. When debate formats reward rapid, information-dense delivery optimized for expert judges, debaters develop procedural habits (speaking patterns, argumentative reflexes, rhetorical strategies) that bleed into their ordinary communication. The problem is that these habits are adapted to a highly specific

audience (trained debate judges) and may actively impede communication with general audiences who lack the training to process such delivery.

This represents a failure of transfer: the procedural rhetoric of these formats teaches that effective persuasion means maximizing information density for expert evaluation, rather than connecting with diverse listeners. The skills that bleed out are real skills, but they are narrowly optimized. Design interventions might include evaluation criteria that reward accessibility alongside substance, or judging paradigms that simulate general rather than expert audiences.

4.2.3 Competitive Pressure and the Compromised Container

The broader concern that competitive optimization undermines educational goals can be understood as a compromise of the transformational container itself. The container's effectiveness depends on maintaining sufficient psychological safety for participants to take risks, experiment, and fail without lasting consequences. When competitive pressures become overwhelming, when tournament success determines status, self-worth, and community standing, the alibi that enables transformation erodes. Participants can no longer treat debate as "just a game" because the stakes have become too real.

This compromise cascades through other mechanisms. Emancipatory bleed, which enables participants from marginalized backgrounds to discover and develop their voice, requires a container where being taken seriously as an intellectual is possible. Rigid status hierarchies based on competitive success can block this bleed for those positioned as subordinate. The zone of proximal development requires challenges calibrated to enable growth; when competitive anxiety dominates, participants may avoid the productive struggle necessary for development, or may be so focused on winning that they cannot engage in the reflective observation essential to learning.

4.2.4 Implications for Design

This theoretical reframing generates specific predictions about design interventions. Formats designed to maximize transformation should: (1) structure memetic bleed toward epistemic humility rather than detachment from conviction, perhaps through debriefing practices that explicitly connect argumentative experiences to personal development; (2) align procedural bleed with transferable communication skills by incorporating evaluation criteria rewarding accessibility; and (3) maintain the container's safety by preventing competitive success from becoming conflated with personal worth, perhaps through structural features that distribute status more broadly or that emphasize growth over victory. These predictions inform the design process described in the Methods section.

5 METHODS

5.1 Design Philosophy

This research employs Research through Design (RtD) as primary methodological framework. RtD positions the design process itself as inquiry, where knowledge emerges through making

and iterating upon designed artifacts (Coulton & Hook, 2017; J. Zimmerman et al., 2007). The design process follows E. Zimmerman (2003) iterative methodology, treating play as research. Each playtest generates data informing subsequent decisions, creating a spiral of refined understanding.

5.2 Development Process

I intend to unfold my process through three cyclical phases.

In the first, generation-oriented, phase I will explore potential mechanics and format elements addressing the theoretically-identified problems, based on game design intuition, established theory, and the integrated framework developed above. Brainstorming sessions, design conversations with debate peers, and analysis of existing formats will be tools I will use to expand possibilities under consideration.

In the second, critical scrutiny-oriented, phase I will dialectically evaluate whether candidate designs congruently address problems without introducing new difficulties (e.g., judge cognitive load, time limitations). The theoretical framework provides evaluation criteria: does this design choice maintain the transformational container's safety? Does it enable productive bleed? Does it support scaffolded learning?

In the third, validation-oriented, phase surviving elements will undergo increasingly rigorous testing: firstly informal design conversations with experienced debaters to surface issues; then small pilot playtests identifying unexpected mechanical problems; and lastly a larger playtest with debate community members using structured observation and interview protocols.

These phases spiral until the format demonstrates sufficient coherence, playability, and alignment with transformational goals, or allocated resources run out. I intend to run two small playtests of one debate each, then a larger playtest as a small full-day competition.

5.3 Research Methods

For analyzing the quality of the design I will organize playtests. During these playtests the research methods used will be observation and semi-structured interviews, followed by a qualitative data analysis.

5.3.1 Participant Observation

Following Baker (2006), I will adopt a participant-as-observer role during playtests. My researcher status will be known, but I will participate actively in some debates to obtain firsthand understanding. When observing debates where not participating, I will function as observer-as-participant: present and known but not actively engaged.

Observation will focus on overall debate flow and more granularly on behaviors relevant to entertainment value, rule legibility and adherence ease, and elements distinct from standard formats, judging whether these indicate positive or negative tendencies vis-à-vis identified problems and the theoretical framework's predictions.

Informed by the advice of Spradley (1980), I will record field notes in two phases: condensed and expanded. Condensed notes, taken during debates, will capture key moments,

quotations, and behavioral observations using structured protocols. Expanded notes, written within 24 hours of the playtests, will elaborate, add contextual observations, and record analytical reflections. All debates will be audio/video-recorded with consent to enable field note verification and capture verbal content not fully documented in real-time.

Anticipated observation includes approximately 10 structured playtest sessions over two months: two sessions with 1–2 individual debates and one larger session with remaining debates.

5.3.2 Participants

I will recruit debaters for playtests with the aid of ARDOR Muntenia, the NGO managing the debate community in Bucharest and the south of Romania. They will both directly inquire various clubs if they are interested in including a playtest as part of their weekly activity and will issue open calls for debaters in organizing the playtests, especially the small competition.

In Romania, the young adults (not minors) debate community is quite homogenous regarding debate experience, as almost all are senior debaters with training experience. Many of these are students or professionals living in Bucharest. The sample answering my open call will likely be representative in debate experience for the most probable target outside this research: experienced, not novice, debaters.

The majority of Romanian debaters are minors. Ideally, the study would involve minor participants, but ethical guidelines pushed toward this strategy as best alternative.

The target sample comprises approximately 30–40 participants across all playtest sessions, with 12–15 participating in semi-structured interviews. This sample size is justified by the proof-of-concept nature of the research: the goal is demonstrating that design-based interventions can produce articulable differences in experience, not establishing generalizable population-level effects. For Research through Design, depth of engagement with fewer participants provides more actionable design insights than breadth with many.

5.3.3 Semi-Structured Interviews

Interviews complement observation by accessing perspectives not directly observable. Interview participants will be recruited through purposive sampling from playtest participants, capturing diverse perspectives: both debaters and judges (offering distinct perspectives); winners and losers (as performance may affect format perception); and different educational backgrounds (primarily teachers/trainers versus debaters).

Following Knott et al. (2022), the target is 12–15 interviews, sufficient for theoretical saturation while remaining feasible. Sampling continues until new interviews cease generating novel themes.

Interviews will center on game feedback, following a topic guide developed based on the particular design reached and iterated upon. Topics will cover general experience (positive/negative, contrast with other formats, difficulty), intentions to play in this format or use elements of it, and issues related to transformative goals as identified through the theoretical framework.

Interviews will occur within one week of participation ensuring fresh recall, ideally immediately after debates. Duration will be approximately 15–20 minutes, conducted in person or via video call depending on preference, and transcribed for analysis.

5.4 Data Analysis

Analysis follows a design-oriented comparative approach. The primary purpose is not generating generalizable theory but informing ongoing design decisions and articulating how the designed format produces different experiences than existing formats. This aligns with experimental game design methodology (Waern & Back, 2015), where design experimentation becomes research when "the aim is to understand something generic, some more fundamental aspect of game design."

5.4.1 Iterative Design Analysis

Between playtest sessions, I will conduct rapid analysis focused on actionable design insights, questioning three core points: What mechanics, rules, dynamics worked, produced intended effects and should be preserved or amplified? What did not work, either by failing to address target problems or by causing confusion, disengagement or unintended consequences? What surprised me and how, and do these suggest new opportunities?

This rapid analysis follows directly from expanded field notes, identifying specific design modifications for next iterations and noting questions or hypotheses for subsequent sessions, treating playtesting as "play as research" (E. Zimmerman, 2003) with each session generating questions informing the next design cycle.

5.4.2 Final Comparative Analysis

After the final playtest, I will conduct systematic comparative analysis of the complete dataset (field notes, observations, interview transcripts, design memos) in three phases.

In the first phase of initial coding, following the advice of Lankoski and Björk (2015), I will identify and label data segments describing participant experiences, behaviors, and reflections. Codes will be descriptive rather than interpretive, capturing what happened rather than meaning.

In the second phase of comparative code analysis, I will organize descriptive codes into comparative categories structured around the theoretical framework's constructs. Within each category, I will code for continuity (experiences similar to traditional formats), difference (experiences diverging from traditional formats), and novelty (experiences unique to the designed format).

In the last phase I will articulate design principles producing identified effects, connecting observed effects to specific format mechanics: Which rules, structures, or dynamics seem responsible? Why might these mechanics produce these effects? Drawing on formal game analysis techniques (Lankoski & Björk, 2015), this examines relationships between game components (rules, roles, constraints), player actions (what the format enables and constrains), and goals (what players are incentivized to pursue). The aim is producing not just observations of difference but explanatory accounts informing future format design.

This approach is designed for proof-of-concept research. The analysis can demonstrate: (a) the designed format produces experiences participants describe as different from traditional formats; (b) specific format mechanics appear connected to specific experiential differences; and (c) these differences align with intended transformative design goals.

The analysis cannot demonstrate that differences persist over time or across contexts, that educational or transformative outcomes are superior rather than different, or that findings generalize beyond the specific participant population. Such claims would require longitudinal, larger-scale research exceeding thesis scope. This limitation is appropriate for Research through Design, where contribution lies in demonstrating that systematic design can address identified problems and in articulating design principles meriting further investigation or usage.

5.5 Ethical Considerations

This research adheres to Uppsala University's ethical guidelines for research involving human participants. All playtest participants will be informed of the purpose and context, how data will be gathered, stored, and analyzed, both during and after recruitment. All will be able to offer and retract consent, granularly or wholesale, to participation in every process part and to data being collected, stored, or used. Peers whose input I use in developing this format will be informed of context and credited. All data will be stored securely in encrypted Microsoft OneDrive offered by Uppsala University, separated by content type, and deleted once thesis development and presentation is complete. All data will be anonymized and not publicly available.

To ensure psychological safety, the rigorous ethical standards imposed by the ARDOR Ethical Guide and ARDOR Trainer Safety Guide will be followed. Debate topics will avoid personal trauma topics and debaters will be able to refuse to engage with motions. Debaters will be able to always talk to a third-party equity officer regarding emotional safety issues and report abusive or distressing behavior. During debates, all debaters will be able to exit without explanation.

Beyond these, all participants will have pre-session briefing and post-session debrief providing chances to address potential distressing elements before activity and discuss experience afterwards.

5.6 Positionality and Reflexivity

I approach this research as a complete community member (Adler & Adler, 1987). My fifteen years in competitive debate have shaped not only my knowledge but my values, assumptions, and emotional investments. This informs several positions that I must acknowledge and address.

First, I bring insider knowledge that enables nuanced understanding of implicit norms, unspoken hierarchies, and lived competition experience. This knowledge is a research resource: I can recognize subtle phenomena that outsiders might miss, interpret participant statements against community context, and engage participants as a peer. However, this familiarity may also create blind spots, assumptions so deeply held that I fail to question them.

Second, I acknowledge my reformist motivation. This research emerges from genuine frustration with existing formats. This predisposes me toward confirming my critique and positions this research as holding rhetorical value within the debate community. I must remain alert to evidence complicating my assumptions and must be transparent throughout about my starting position.

Third, I recognize the novelty of my disciplinary lens. I approach debate through game design and transformative play frameworks rather than the educational, civic, or rhetorical lenses most common in forensics scholarship. This privileges certain questions (How do mechanics shape experience? What transformations does play enable?) while potentially obscuring others.

Fourth, I must address power dynamics created by my status as former Team Romania coach, ARDOR board member, and overall successful debater. Some participants may wish to please or impress me; others to challenge or diminish my work. Former students, colleagues, or mentees may feel particular pressure to provide supportive feedback.

My relationship with the specific formats being critiqued also requires reflection. I achieved competitive success within World Schools and British Parliamentary debate. This creates tension: does my critique emerge from someone who succeeded despite format limitations, or someone shaped by those limitations in ways I cannot fully perceive? My positive experiences with these formats may bias me toward underestimating their problems; alternatively, my deep familiarity may enable recognition of subtle issues invisible to casual participants.

Several practices will support ongoing reflexive awareness. Throughout data collection and analysis, I will maintain a reflexive journal documenting emotions, realizations, decisions, and dilemmas. Following Knott et al. (2022), each interview will be followed by a reflexive note. During analysis, I will actively seek data contradicting expectations or emerging interpretations, trying not to marginalize negative cases. Regular discussion with my thesis supervisor and fellow researchers from within and outside the debate community will provide external perspectives.

Given the likelihood some participants will be known to me, specific strategies will address relationship-related bias. Recruitment will be externalized to ARDOR Muntenia staff to include debaters I have not previously coached or worked with directly. During analysis, I will flag data from participants with whom I have close prior relationships and consider whether relationship dynamics may have influenced responses. Where possible, I will triangulate self-report data with observational data less susceptible to social desirability effects.

Complete elimination of positionality effects is neither possible nor desirable, as my insider knowledge and reputation are also resources enabling this research.

6 Conclusion

Alfred "Tuna" Snider was first to recognize debate as a game and to apply play logic to its analysis, doing this way before game design was a recognized discipline. Through his career as a teacher and scholar he championed the transformative power of playing this game with joy, passion and determination. Although many of his students, one of whom I was very privileged to be, did continue his work in fields such as civics, education, rhetoric and his

own specialty of forensics, none used game-design know-how to answer the question that most naturally flows from his argument that debate is a game: how can we make it a better game?

This thesis seeks to begin answering that question. By applying transformative game design theory to competitive debate, it aims to demonstrate that systematic design interventions can address identified problems while preserving debate's documented benefits. The contribution lies not in producing a finished format but in establishing proof of concept: that the intersection of game design scholarship and forensics pedagogy offers productive tools for format improvement, and in articulating design principles worthy of further development and investigation.

Timeline Annex

- **01–15 January:** Thesis proposal refining
- **16–31 January:** Design of the new format, conversations with fellow senior debaters and with other game designers; organizing the first playtest
- **01–15 February:** First pilot playtest, first interviews, announcing the mini-competition and opening registration, iteration on the game design
- **16–28 February:** Second pilot playtest and interviews, finishing registrations for the mini-competition, iteration on the game design
- **01–20 March:** Mini-competition extensive playtests, running all remaining interviews
- **21 March–01 May:** Data analysis, further theoretical inquiries, thesis writing

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